

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: AP Photo/Mark Schiefelbein

Donald Trump picked Bill Pulte, a loyalist and head of a federal housing agency, to become the acting Director of National Intelligence. Mr Pulte is replacing Tulsi Gabbard, who announced she would [step down last month](#). While at the housing agency he pushed the Justice Department [to investigate several of the president's foes](#) for mortgage fraud. He has no previous national-security experience.

Russia launched more than 600 drones and missiles against several cities in Ukraine, according to Ukraine's air force. At least 22 people were killed, and hundreds more injured in one of Russia's biggest assaults in months. Ukrainian officials have suggested that more people are trapped under rubble. [Struggling to advance](#) on the front line, Russia has in recent months stepped up its attacks on civilian areas.

Mr Trump claimed that **Israel** and **Hizbullah** had [agreed to scale back attacks](#) on one another, and that Binyamin Netanyahu had called off a "major raid" on Beirut, Lebanon's capital. Lebanese officials confirmed a partial ceasefire agreement and are meeting with their Israeli counterparts in Washington. Even so, fighting

resumed in southern Lebanon, threatening American peace negotiations with Iran.

Mr Trump signed an executive order requesting **artificial-intelligence** companies allow the government to vet powerful models 30 days before their release to any others. A scaled-back version of an earlier proposal, it nonetheless marks a shift toward federal oversight. Meanwhile **Anthropic** offered its latest “Mythos” tool to 150 other organisations, including the EU’s cybersecurity agency. The AI lab claims it is too [powerful](#) to release to the public immediately.

An **El Niño**, the weather pattern which raises global temperatures and alters rainfall, is expected to start imminently, according to the **World Meteorological Organisation**. Some forecasts indicate that it could be the strongest such event in decades. If so, it will substantially increase the risks of extreme weather such as droughts and torrential rainfall over the next nine to twelve months.

The **World Health Organisation** revised down the number of suspected Ebola cases in the [latest outbreak](#) in the Democratic Republic of Congo. There have been 321 confirmed cases and 116 suspected ones in the country. Meanwhile, **Kenya’s** top court extended a block on the construction of an Ebola quarantine centre for American citizens for three more weeks. Two people died on Monday in protests against the facility.

The **EU parliament’s** trade committee voted to remove tariffs on several American products to comply with [the deal](#) struck between the EU and America last year. Last month Donald Trump had threatened the bloc with additional tariffs if it did not implement its part of the agreement by July 4th. The EU bill faces a final vote by the whole parliament in mid-June.

Figure of the day: 40,000, the number of people who buy *Country Life* magazine each week. Find out [why the British publication is](#)

thriving.



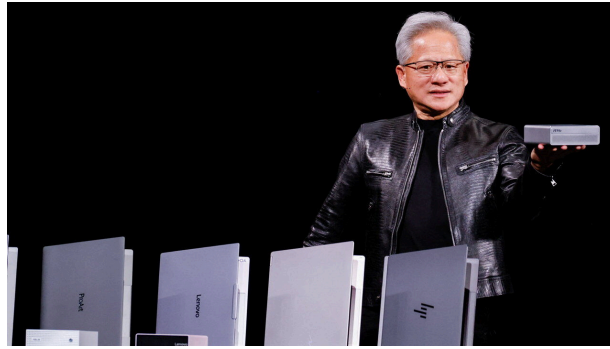
Photograph: Getty Images

Question time for Marco Rubio

America's secretary of state, who doubles as Donald Trump's [national security adviser](#), starts a tough two days in Congress on Tuesday. Marco Rubio will appear before four separate groups of lawmakers, including the influential Senate Foreign Relations Committee and House Foreign Affairs Committee. They are likely to press Mr Rubio on a range of topics. America and Iran exchanged missile strikes over the weekend, amid talks to end the war. Lawmakers will comb through the finer points of a nascent deal.

They are also concerned that the administration may be preparing to attack Cuba, whose former leader, Raúl Castro, America indicted recently. Mr Rubio is of Cuban heritage and has long taken a hawkish line on the island's regime. Taiwan is also likely to come up.

Mr Rubio is talked of as a contender for the Republican presidential nomination in 2028. The hearings will test his ability to preserve his credibility while selling Mr Trump's increasingly capricious foreign policy.



Photograph: Reuters

Nvidia brings AI to the PC

The [semiconductor company](#) best known for making the chips that power artificial-intelligence data centres is muscling in on the personal-computer business. This week at Computex, a big trade show in Taiwan, Jensen Huang, Nvidia’s boss, unveiled a chip that directly challenges Intel and AMD, two rival designers that dominate the market.

Nvidia is no stranger to the consumer market. Before the AI boom, it made most of its money selling graphics-processing units for gaming PCs. But the rise of “agentic” AI—in which systems carry out complex tasks on their own—is changing the hardware that personal computers need. Nvidia says its new design is the first aimed at running AI agents on PCs.

To support the move, Mr Huang has spent the past week wooing bosses of critical suppliers, including SK Hynix, a South Korean memory-maker, and TSMC, the Taiwanese chipmaking giant, over dinners around Taipei. These meals have become a spectator sport, with crowds gathering outside for a glimpse of Mr Huang, the chip industry’s poster boy.



Photograph: Alamy

Europe's inflation mystification

New data for the euro zone, released on Tuesday, shows that the increase in fuel costs caused by war in the Middle East is feeding through to prices elsewhere. At 3.2%, the headline rate is uncomfortably high. Energy-price inflation reached almost 11%. Even core inflation—the rate that strips out volatile prices such as energy—ticked up to 2.5% in May. Consequently, investors expect the European Central Bank to raise its main interest rate from 2% to 2.25% on June 11th.

The bank faces a difficult decision. The ECB's latest inflation-expectations survey shows that, over the medium-term, consumers expect a rate of 2.9%, down from 3% a month earlier. Banks' lending standards have already tightened without any action by the ECB, in part because [economic growth](#) has taken a hit from the oil shock and made lending riskier. Unlike in 2022, when prices last spikes, the European economy is already struggling.



Photograph: Reuters

Will the next governor of California please stand up?

The race to lead California is the state's most chaotic and consequential election in years. Term limits mean Gavin Newsom, the Democratic incumbent, cannot run again, and there is [no heir apparent](#) (largely because he has not endorsed anyone). In a primary on Tuesday, the top two, regardless of party, will advance to the general election in November.

Polling suggests that one Republican, Steve Hilton (a former adviser to David Cameron, a British prime minister), and two Democrats, Xavier Becerra (a former cabinet secretary for Joe Biden) and Tom Steyer (a climate-campaigning billionaire), have [the best chances](#). No Republican has won statewide in California since 2006; even if Mr Hilton makes it through, he is almost sure not to be elected. Mr Steyer's progressivism makes big business queasy and Mr Becerra rarely offers any plans at all. Democrats with experience in Sacramento, the state capital, or in local government have floundered. Mr Newsom may come to regret his silence.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Casement, sash and bay are types of which architectural feature?

Monday: The British ships *HMS Erebus* and *HMS Terror* were lost in 1845 in the attempt to navigate which waterway?

*Women, like men, ought to have
their years so glutted with
freedom that they hate the very
idea of freedom.*

Vita Sackville-West